The Bane of Wilsonianism:

How Wilson and his actions destroyed the hope of global Wilsonian future

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History 319

Introduction and Approach

World War I ravaged the European continent, cleaving centuries-old empires into pieces and slaughtering the populations of the Allies and Central Powers alike. After leading the United States into the war and guaranteeing the Allied victory, Woodrow Wilson stood as the central figure to whom people sought hope in the post-war world. Wilson was not only the President of the United States but had been a historian and past President of Princeton University.[1] Therefore, he was not just a politician but a political theorist, pushing a new brand of international relations that would eventually be dubbed Wilsonianism. Wilsonianism centered on the idea of global peace between nation-states secured through self-determination ensured by worldwide trade and open diplomacy networks.[2]

Following the end of World War I, there seemed to be a global reckoning and hope for this Wilsonian future. Wilson issued his famous Fourteen Points speech during the war to increase international support for the Allied cause. These fourteen points outlined his Wilsonian vision for a post-war world order through self-determination and the creation of an international body to increase diplomatic transparency.[3] Wilson and many of his contemporaries viewed this as the perfect moment to create a future based on Wilsonian values that would ensure global peace following such a brutal and violent war.

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[1] Barry Hankins, *Woodrow Wilson: Ruling Elder, Spiritual President*, Spiritual Lives(Oxford, 2016; online edn, Oxford Academic, 23 June 2016), 65-67.
[2] Daniel Immerwahr, "Wilsonian Moment" (lecture, Northwestern University, Evanston, IL, January 25, 2024)
[3] Woodrow Wilson, "President Woodrow Wilson's 14 Points (1918) | National Archives."

Wilson went to Europe to handle the Paris Peace Conference personally and the creation of what would become the Treaty of Versailles. Also in Paris were the British Prime Minister David Lloyd George, French Prime Minister Georges Clemenceau, Italian Prime Minister Vittorio Orlando, dozens of leaders from other countries, colonies, interest groups, and vast entourages for each respective leader.[4] Wilson had the backing of America's enormous financial and material resources, so he led most of the negotiations.[5] Because of this, all relevant parties agreed to accept the Fourteen Points speech as a framework for peace discussions in what seemed to be a global acceptance for a Wilsonian future.[6]

Historians have highlighted the peace conference as a moment when hopes of a Wilsonian future seemed most expansive. The promises laid out in his Fourteen Points attracted the attention of citizens worldwide, making Wilson the most powerful and influential man in the world for a brief time.[7] Yet this paper argues that while he might have been the most influential man then, his direct role in the peace process hurt his reputation and ultimately harmed his ability to translate his ideas into reality. Woodrow Wilson's involvement in negotiations at the Paris Peace Conference led to the failure of a Wilsonian future materializing after World War I.

The negotiations on the Treaty of Versailles took place in two theaters, in the United States and at the conference in Paris. This paper will first examine how Wilson gravely misunderstood European politics and affairs following the World War and how this negatively impacted the Wilsonian future that seemed to be brewing. Following that, the paper will investigate how Wilson's personality and negotiation tactics clashed with other leaders and tainted the reputation of himself and his ideas. Then, this paper will analyze how Wilson's failure

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[4] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 18.
[5] Ibid.
[6] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Charlottesville: University of Virginia Press, Rotunda, 2017. Volume 64. This recollection comes from the personal diary of Colonel Edward House, a delegate with the American peace commission about a meeting of the Council of Four.
[7] Daniel Immerwahr, "Wilsonian Moment".

to compromise and listen on the domestic front led to the failure of ratification in the United States, dealing the death blow to hopes of a Wilsonian future.

Internationally Inexperienced: Wilson's Misunderstandings of Europe Post World War I

Upon his arrival in France, Wilson was greeted by masses of French citizens cheering him on as the central leader of the Allied defense of their country.[8] Like people worldwide, they viewed Wilson as the one to bring about lasting global peace. However, Wilson had little experience with the realities of politics within Europe and did not have a grasp on the way the war affected the continent.

Germany had lost World War I and had signed the armistice saying such, however, the German citizenry did not feel as if they had lost. A narrative arose following the armistice signing that Germany had not lost the war, but rather, the leaders of Germany surrendered cowardly.[9] Since the Kaiser had fled to the Netherlands and the fighting of the war never spilled into German territory, there was no tangible evidence of the German defeat. Allied leaders proposed military marches into Berlin to assert the victory.[10] Still, nothing ever materialized that might have signaled to the German people that they had little military left to oppose the Allied powers. Wilson learned about the false narrative early upon his arrival from the general of all Allied forces, Ferdinand Foch, and did not work to combat it within Germany.[11]

The sentiment that the German people were innocent was upheld in part in the Fourteen Points and other addresses when Wilson did not blame Germany for its greatness or power but instead blamed the government of Germany for their aggression.[12] Since the Allied leaders

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[8] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. Entry in the personal diary of Dr. Cary T. Grayson, personal aide to the President dated December 13, 1918.
[9] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 99.
[10] Ibid.
[11] "Cary T. Grayson Diary · Woodrow Wilson Presidential Library & Museum, Staunton, Virginia.". Another personal entry to Dr. Grayson's diary dated December 17, 1918.
[12] "Address to Congress · Woodrow Wilson Presidential Library & Museum, Staunton, Virginia." The address Wilson gave to Congress after Germany signed the armistice.

denied German representation at the conference, the German people lauded the Fourteen Points. They hoped that Wilson would secure a peace treaty based on its principles.[13] When Wilson failed in this regard, German citizens were infuriated. Fanning their ire was a German media machine that amplified the most humiliating parts of the treaty. The media machine kicked into action when the French maneuvered the conference into adding a war guilt clause that blamed Germany alone for the war. The German media ran with this once the Council of Four released the terms of the treaty. The German citizens were bitter that Wilson had not secured the peace they thought he promised in his Fourteen Points speech.[14] This bitterness and resentment festered, breeding radicalism and broader social unrest, which brought about the rise of the Nazis and the remilitarization of the German state in the lead-up to World War Two. Wilson knew the German people did not feel responsible for or suffer any real effects of the war, banking on him to guarantee a fair treaty. Instead, he and the other leaders forced them to sign a treaty, blaming them for the entire war and making them pay seemingly insane reparations.[15] By not understanding the German feelings and mindset after the war, Wilson inadvertently led to another global war, opposing his stated ideas of international peace.

Another way in which Wilson did not understand the political landscape of Europe came in the form of an ever-present fear of Bolshevism. Russia had fallen into revolution during the war, and Lenin and the Bolsheviks had taken control of the government. In the aftermath of the war, Wilson's Secretary of State, Robert Lansing, sent Wilson a memorandum detailing how the Bolshevik threat might expand in the now significantly weaker Eastern European region.[16] They shared the fear that Bolshevism would spread into Germany while it was in flux before the peace

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[13] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 99.
[14] Ibid.
[15] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 82.
[16] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. From Robert Lansing to Woodrow Wilson with a Memorandum dating November 18, 1918.

conference finished. To combat this fear, Wilson constantly insisted that negotiations should be swift and despised any attempts to stall or hold sweeping discussions on topics.[17]

His central method of speeding up the negotiations was to create a small council from which to operate. After the first few meetings of large bodies such as the Supreme War Council and the Council of Ten, Wilson realized that the breadth of the meetings significantly decreased the efficiency and the speed of negotiations.[18] Following this realization, Wilson started working within a group of just the four leaders of the most significant Allied powers. This group became known as the Council of Four, composed of Wilson, Clemenceau, Lloyd George, and Orlando. They would often hear input from other sources, but the small group led most of the foundation of principle points of the treaty.[19] The group's small size increased efficiency but at the cost of the input of the significant number of experts within the entourages of the leaders and the more minor powers attending the conference.

The Council of Four stood in stark opposition to Wilson's idea of open diplomacy. Secretive, small treaties Wilson thought of as one of the primary causes for World War One.[20] However, Wilson willingly set aside this idea and negotiated with a small, secretive group to achieve his efficiency and speed goals at the conference. By disregarding the fundamental concepts behind his political view to achieve his goal, he significantly harmed the reputation of his ideas as they were not strong enough for even himself to uphold them in difficult times.

Yet another way that Wilson misunderstood the politics of Europe at the time was when he tried to apply his idea of self-determination and nationalism to a continent that knew primarily imperial rule for centuries. This imperial rule resulted in ethnicities and nationalities dispersed

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[17] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. Upset and ill, Wilson ordered his boat be brought around out of disdain for French stalling tactics, from the diary of Dr. Grayson, dated April 7, 1918.
[18] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 18.
[19] Ibid.
[20] Woodrow Wilson, "President Woodrow Wilson's 14 Points (1918) | National Archives."

across Europe without regard for clean borders. For instance, after the fall of the Austro-Hungarian Empire, the area consisted of a mess of Poles, Bulgarians, Czechs, Austrians, Hungarians, Italians, and Romanians, to name only a few.[21] These groups now had complex and overlapping claims to large swaths of land. When deciding where national boundaries should be during the conference, there were often disputes and disagreements. Sometimes, the Allied powers planned plebiscites to settle a region's national identity.[22] On top of this, when creating new states in Eastern Europe, the Council of Four would often add lands that may have been different from the majority of the country's nationality if there were other goals to achieve. For example, sometimes lands would be added to a country for strategic military or economic reasons so the country hopefully would be strong enough to survive and provide an Eastern buffer to German and Bolshevik aggressions.[23]

Even with many new nation-states being created based on these various claims to right over a particular land, the right to self-determination was sometimes disregarded for more significant political interests within the treaty negotiations. Fiume was an important port city for a proposed new Yugoslavian state. However, it also contained a large Italian population, which would determine itself to be Italian.[24] The Council of Four, after repeated attempts by Italian Prime Minister Orlando to the contrary, ruled that Fiume would be a free state at the time of signing and left to a commission to decide later as it was strategically important to the new state

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[21] "Nationalities (Austria-Hungary) | International Encyclopedia of the First World War (WW1)." International Encyclopedia of the First World War (WW1).
[22] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 60. Notes from the meeting of the Council of Four taken by Sir Maurice Hankey, British politician attending the conference who took the minutes of many of the meetings of the Council of Four.
[23] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 43-44.
[24] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 57. Another diary entry from Dr. Grayson about meetings Wilson had regarding the Italian's Orlando and Sonino arguing their case in front of the Council of Four, dated April 21, 1919.

of Yugoslavia.[25] In some cases, The failure of self-determination diluted the principle's power during the conference.

Wilson also freely admitted in a private meeting that the conference had failed to uphold the promises of self-determination and self-rule to a group of Irish representatives.[26] The representatives had come to push their claim for independence from Britain, which Wilson knew he could not deliver upon. In a moment of openness, Wilson admitted that they had failed many regions, and these regions would have to push for self-rule later by using arms.[27] Wilson acknowledged that he had failed to uphold his principles. He proposed that these small states use military force to achieve their goals instead of proper negotiation and diplomacy, a very non-Wilsonian idea.

Lastly, the final treaty and its newly defined nation-states made war more of a possibility than it had been otherwise. For example, by attempting to create small states based on the nationalities and ethnicities in the former Austro-Hungarian Empire, a series of small powers arose, directly abutting the German state.[28] The German state was incensed over the treaty's terms and the idea that the Allied powers unfairly punished them for their leaders' actions.[29] While upholding one end of Wilsonian thought and attempting to satisfy the right to self-determination, Wilson failed to realize that the consequences of these actions would lead to a far more angry Germany facing a series of weaker states around it with large German populations it could exploit to start its expansion.

Poor Negotiator: Wilson's Lack of International Diplomatic Prowess

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[25] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 64. Later correspondence from Clemenceau to Wilson that references the final agreement in the Fiume matter after the conference had ended. Dated January 15, 1920.
[26] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 60. Diary entry from Dr. Grayson dated June 11, 1919 detailing the meeting between the Irish Representatives and Wilson.
[27] Ibid.
[28] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, xiii.
[29] Ibid, 100.

International diplomacy at as high a level as the Paris Peace Conference is a series of compromises. The negotiators must understand what the other parties want and how much they will give up to secure it. At the Paris Peace Conference, Wilson needed to grasp fully what the other leaders were bargaining for. Instead, he clumsily negotiated, sacrificing key Wilsonian ideas, and would often shove his ideas through without compromise leading to a decline in his reputation.

Wilson failed to realize that the balance of power politics that had thrust Europe into the war remained after the armistice signing. For instance, French goals throughout the conference relied on gaining the power never to be attacked by Germany again.[30] France wished to accomplish this by gaining security guarantees from Britain and the United States and establishing a solid state on the other side of Germany now that Russia had fallen into revolution.[31] Negotiating for this state led to France taking a hard-line stance on establishing the Polish state that would require the borders of Poland to extend beyond areas with a majority of Polish populations. A key sticking point in this debate was the port city of Danzig. Danzig had a majority German population, given all the data the leaders acquired, but it was a necessary port for the new Polish state to have. After extensive discussion, the final agreement was for Danzig to be an "independent city" but with a path dividing German territory into two and ceding German majority lands to the Polish state to ensure its access to the critical port.[32]

Along with his misunderstanding of the French position, he also misunderstood the British position. The British had formed a tenuous peace with the French during the war out of obligation for the treaties central to both powers. However, Britain still deeply distrusted the

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[30] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. Diary entry from Colonel Edward House dated January 7, 1919 detailing a meeting he and Wilson had with Prime Minister Clemenceau.
[31] Ibid.
[32] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 57. Meeting notes of the Council of Four where a large discussion surrounding Danzig took place. Authored by Étienne Mantoux, a French economist present at the meeting on April 9, 1919.

French and did not want a French state so strong that it would just replace a German hegemony with a French one.[33] They reluctantly agreed to a security agreement with the United States that they would come to the aid of France should Germany ever invade again. Still, they left it worded so that if the Treaty of Versailles failed ratification in the United States, they did not have to uphold their end.[34]

Not only did Wilson not understand the position of his co-negotiators, but they often recognized and capitalized on his clear preference for the League of Nations. In one example, Lloyd-George recognized that Wilson cared primarily about the League of Nations and threatened to withdraw his support for it over an issue of a United States naval build-up.[35] In another example, to appease France and bring them on board with other proposals, Wilson had to secure their guarantee of a separate security deal with both Britain and the United States.[36] The security agreement again violated Wilson's beliefs by creating a military treaty that would embroil all three states in a war without the League of Nations consultation. In a purely Wilsonian world, this document would not be necessary as the conflict would come up for discussion within the League of Nations, but Clemenceau demanded it, and to secure his blessing in other key areas, Wilson had to sacrifice his ideals again. Wilson's lack of diplomatic prowess bogged the treaty with compromises that violated Wilsonian ideals.

Wilson's involvement also meant that his personality and the personalities of the Premiers of the other states started seeping into and affecting the negotiations. Wilson, coming into the conference, had an expansive mandate and maintained much of it as the central financial

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[33] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 36-37.
[34] Sally Marks, "Mistakes and Myths: The Allies, Germany, and the Versailles Treaty, 1918–1921." 647
[35] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 56. From a diary entry of Lord Robert Cecil dated March 26, 1919, describing a conversation he had with British Prime Minister David Lloyd George.
[36] Sally Marks, "Mistakes and Myths: The Allies, Germany, and the Versailles Treaty, 1918–1921." 647

power of the Allies.[37] The United States' vast economic power meant that the other states often bowed to the United States over issues they might have pushed back on otherwise. This power, however, made Wilson frequently act straightforwardly, pushing his agenda ahead of all others and making him appear much like a bully to the European leaders and their people.

In one key example, the French had been stalling for time to determine what they wished to charge Germany with regarding reparations for the war. After multiple meetings with few accomplishments, Wilson had the navy bring his boat to port and threatened to withdraw from the conference if the attendees continued to waste time as the French had, in his opinion, been doing.[38] Similarly, in a later conflict with the French, French Premier Clemenceau had altered the treaty draft right before the vote approved it. This enraged Wilson as the treaty was so long that monitoring for such minor changes was tricky. He messaged Clemenceau demanding he change it. When Clemenceau did not, he took it upon himself and altered the treaty even though it had been approved by all plenipotentiaries the day prior, with the change included.[39]

While holding Wilson in high regard in the public and press, many of his co-negotiators started to view him as an uncompromising bully who would do anything to achieve his aims. Despite constant negotiations and Wilson caving to demands that violated his ideals, his peers viewed him as exceptionally steadfast in his beliefs and strong-willed. Lord Robert Cecil, a critical British negotiator, wrote of such in his diary. Cecil recollects from his first meeting that "[Wilson] is, if one may say so, a trifle of a bully, and must be dealt with firmly, though with the utmost courtesy and respect—not a very easy combination to hit off. He is also evidently a vain

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[37] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 56. From a diary entry of Lord Robert Cecil dated March 26, 1919, reflecting the need of money and Europe with the United States being the only significant source available, giving them considerable negotiating powers.
[38] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 57. Entry from the personal diary of Dr. Grayson dated April 7, 1919 discussing Grayson's attempt to obfuscate the requisition of the boat to the media.
[39] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 58. Entry from the personal diary of Dr. Grayson dated May 5, 1919.

man, and still with an eye all the time on the American elections."[40] This perception of Wilson seeped out occasionally during the negotiations with the French and British press. At one point, Colonel House, from the American delegation, told the President that remaining in France would only harm his reputation and that it would be better if he headed home.[41] Wilson rejected this, remaining, which led to his reputation tanking internationally and reflecting poorly upon his eponymous Wilsonian ideas around the world.

My Fellow Americans: Wilson's Stubborn Domestic Political Struggle and Ultimate Failure

Wilson repeatedly did not listen to those around him, even those who looked out for what was best for him and his ideas. For instance, before Wilson created the American conference delegation, his Secretary of State, Robert Lansing, sent a memorandum to Wilson imploring him to remain in the United States for the duration of the negotiations. He thought it could damage the President's reputation to sully himself among the negotiators, and staying in the United States indirectly afforded him the most considerable power over negotiations.[42] Wilson ignored Lansing here and repeatedly throughout the conference. In a later example, Lansing responded to the first draft of the League of Nations covenant. He was opposed to a lot of the wording in the first draft. When Lansing and other members of the American delegation pushed back on Wilson's ideas, Wilson was surprisingly resistant to their opinions. He also declared that he did not want the treaty draft written by a lawyer, which seemed to be a direct dig at Lansing, a lawyer before being appointed to be Secretary of State.[43]

Later in the conference, there was a proposal to keep the terms and conditions of the treaty within the Council of Four until the last possible minute. The argument went that before they sent out the treaty terms, they ought to hear Germany's counteroffer and adjust accordingly

[40] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 54. Entry from the diary of Lord Cecil dated January 19, 1919.
[41] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 56. Entry from the diary of Colonel House dated March 22, 1919.
[42] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. Memorandum from Lansing to Wilson dated November 18, 1918.
[43] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 54. Memorandum from Lansing dated January 11, 1919.

instead of publishing an incomplete treaty. Lansing argued that the four powers dictating the terms and not showing any minor states present until after Germany had signed would be equivalent to an oligarchy by the big four nations.[44] Lansing argued there should be a more open diplomatic process that included these other states, a very Wilsonian stance. Wilson again did not heed the warning and kept the document secret. Wilson repeatedly disregarded Lansing when he looked out for Wilson's reputation and his ideas.

Along with Lansing, another member of the Peace Commission, Colonel Edward M. House, drew Wilson's ire repeatedly for seeking compromise with the European powers and releasing some information to the press. When Wilson returned to America in March of 1919, he left Colonel House as his primary representative in matters of negotiations with the leaders of the other powers. Upon his return, Wilson discovered that Colonel House had negotiated with the French and British, who had proposed a preliminary treaty without the League of Nations covenant. Wilson bitterly objected to this and spent the following week enforcing his demand that the League of Nations was essential to the treaty.[45] Colonel House was pushing for a more open, diplomatic process, and yet again, Wilson denied his wishes and, by extension, the Wilsonian principles on which they were based.

By failing to work even within his delegation and accept critique and their suggestions, Wilson worked against his self-interest and the interest of Wilsonian ideas. By repeatedly insisting on staying in Paris for the peace conference, he risked his reputation and, by extension, the reputation of his ideas. Similarly, when both Colonel House and Lansing argued for inherently Wilsonian ideas, like improving access to the treaty or engaging in meaningful diplomacy that didn't rely solely on brute force, Wilson shot them down.

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[44] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 57. Letter from Lansing to Wilson dated April 12, 1919.
[45] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 57. Diary entry from Dr. Grayson dated April 21, 1919.

Wilson often failed to negotiate at the conference, similar to his failure to compromise or negotiate over the treaty domestically. Any treaty in the United States must be signed by the President and then approved by the Senate. The 1918 election brought a Republican wave, so the influential Foreign Relations Committee was firmly under Republican control when Wilson attended the conference.[46] Instead of reaching across the aisle and including a Republican senator in his delegation, he did not include a Republican or Senator from the Foreign Relations Committee.[47] His failure to include any senator in the treaty creation or negotiation was part of the reason the treaty failed to pass in the Senate in 1920.

Along with failing to include Republican Senators in the original mission, he did not bow to their repeated warnings that they would actively work against the treaty when it arrived in the United States. Wilson returned to the United States for a stint in March of 1919 to rally more support for the treaty. During his trip back, Republican senators sent correspondence to Wilson stating they would only support a preliminary treaty that did not include the League of Nations Covenant.[48] Wilson, believing he had the support of the people, rebuffed these warnings and returned to Paris, actively working to ensure the treaty included the League of Nations.

Another instance where he failed to compromise with Senate Republicans over the treaty was after the conference had finished and the treaty was under consideration for ratification. Wilson met with senators from the Committee on Foreign Relations and tried to answer their questions and assuage their worries over the treaty.[49] The senators sought to add reservations to the treaty when they passed it to opt the United States out of certain parts of the treaty and retain

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[46] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 53. Information sent from Congressman Stephens on the predicted reasons for the losses of the election of 1918, dated November 12, 1918.
[47] Michael S. Neiberg, 2017, *The Treaty of Versailles*, 13-14.
[48] *The Papers of Woodrow Wilson Digital Edition.* Volume 55. Diary entry from Dr. Grayson dated March 3, 1919.
[49] United States, Congress, Senate. "Treaty of peace with Germany. Report of the conference between members of the Senate Committee on Foreign Relations and the President of the United States at the White House, Tuesday, August 19, 1919. Presented by Mr. Lodge. August 20, 1919.

its sovereignty in crucial areas. During this meeting, Wilson pushed back heavily on the idea of reservations as he thought that approval of reservations would mean that the reservations would have to be approved by all treaty signatories.[50]

Wilson's failure to compromise and negotiate domestically led to a prolonged battle when he returned from Europe in the summer of 1919. Wilson officially submitted the treaty to the Senate Foreign Relations Committee on July 10, 1919.[51] When the treaty came up for a vote in November of 1919, it was attached to a series of reservations proposed by Senate Foreign Relations Committee Chairman Henry Lodge that Wilson despised. These reservations kept the United States out of many of the commissions and obligations to which it was committed in the plain text of the treaty.[52] In a turn of events, Wilson sent a note to his fellow Democrats to vote against the treaty.[53] Following another vote in March of 1920 without reservations, failing because Lodge withheld his support, the treaty was dead in the Senate.[54] In the lead-up to the election of 1920, he banked on the support of Americans across the country to put pressure on their senators, saying the election was a national referendum on the treaty. In a blow to this theory, the Republican, Warren G. Harding, won handily with an electoral victory of 404 to 127.[55] While the treaty was not the only issue on the ballot, Wilson's hopes that the treaty would motivate a large turnout and support the treaty back into the public consciousness disappeared with the loss.

Wilson's prolonged domestic fight over the treaty and lack of ratification killed any hope of enforcement of the tenuous peace deal. The American backing of many of the treaty items was necessary for it to function correctly. For instance, Britain cared little for the French fear of

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[50] Ibid.
[51] "U.S. Senate: Woodrow Wilson Submits the Treaty of Versailles." U.S. Senate.
[52] "U.S. Senate: Senate Rejects the Treaty of Versailles." U.S. Senate.
[53] Ibid.
[54] *New York Times*. 1920. "The Senate Kills Treaty," March 20, 1920.
[55] "1920 Electoral College Results | National Archives." 2019. National Archives. November 5, 2019.

re-invasion. When the Germans did not adhere strictly to the treaty's terms or toed the line concerning reparations, France asked for aid and received only apathy.[56] Once Germany realized they could ignore some of the treaty's terms, in acts of rebellion against the terms, they started to frequently skirt their end of the bargain, making France even more upset over the situation.

Conclusions

The Treaty of Versailles and the Paris Peace Conference are subject to endless study; historians, diplomats, and politicians all attempt to decipher where it went wrong. The Potsdam Conference explicitly stated in its aims that it wanted to avoid the same fate as the Paris Peace Conference from twenty-five years prior.[57] In these analyses and histories of the conference, blame lies on various factors. Yet, this paper contends Wilson himself was the primary reason for the failure of Wilsonian thought within the conference.

Wilson's failure to understand Europe and his fellow leaders with whom he was negotiating led to a weaker bargaining position, which other leaders used adeptly against him. His constant insistence on his path led to many different parties at the conference disliking him, including members of his delegation. Wilson's failure to negotiate and compromise angered the politically opposed Senate members. The lack of compromise led to the failure of ratification, which was the end of enforcement of the treaty and the power of the League of Nations. These actions, in concert, led to the dilution of Wilsonian ideas in the treaty's process and final document. While the path to peace was always going to be difficult, because of his heavy personal involvement and actions, Wilson ensured that a Wilsonian peace never materialized.

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[56] Sally Marks, "Mistakes and Myths: The Allies, Germany, and the Versailles Treaty, 1918–1921." *The Journal of Modern History* 85, no. 3 (2013), 656.
[57] Neiberg, Michael S. 2017. *The Treaty of Versailles*. Oxford University Press, 101.

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